

Smushie - (companion emotion robot)

Quick User Guide

What is Smushie?

Smushie is a small companion robot that reacts to your **voice** and **touch**. It uses coloured lights and gentle vibration patterns to reflect and respond to how you sound and interact with it, aiming to help you feel calmer and more centred.

What Smushie Does

- Listens to short phrases you say through a nearby microphone
 - Interprets the emotional tone (for example happy, calm, sad, or angry).
 - Shows the emotion using:
 - Changing colours and light patterns inside its body.
 - Different vibration rhythms that you can feel when you touch it.
 - Remembers which patterns you touch more for each emotion and starts using those patterns more often.
-

How to Use Smushie

Placing Smushie

- Put Smushie somewhere stable in your room or on a desk where you can easily see and reach it.
- Make sure its power cable is safely routed and not a trip hazard.

When Smushie Activates

- During normal operation, Smushie stays quietly in the background.
- If its sensing suggests you may be distressed (for example, raised voice, agitation, or similar cues), it will:
 - Light up with an appropriate colour pattern.
 - Start a gentle vibration to attract your attention.

This is Smushie inviting you to come closer and interact.

Comfort Interaction

- When Smushie is lit and vibrating, you can:
 - Gently place your hand on the surface.
 - Stroke or pat it as you would a small pet.
- As you interact:
 - The lights and vibration may continue or slowly change pattern, depending on how Smushie is configured.
 - The system treats your continued touch as a sign that this kind of response is helpful, so it becomes more likely to use similar patterns again.

You can stay with Smushie as long as you like, it is designed as a quiet, tactile focus to help you calm down.

When Smushie Settles

- After a while, or when the system no longer detects signs of distress, Smushie will gradually fade its lights and reduce or stop vibration.
- It returns to a resting state, ready to activate again if you later seem distressed.

What the Colours and Vibration Mean (example)

Smushie may use patterns such as:

- **Warm, bright colours + more active vibration**
 - Used when it “believes” more energy and reassurance might be helpful e.g. for strong frustration or anger or anxious
- **Soft, cool colours + slow, gentle vibration**
 - Used when it “believes” a calming, soothing response is better e.g. sadness or general distress or just feeling low
- **Neutral, soft white glow + very subtle vibration or none**
 - Used when things are stable, or when winding down after a period of distress.

Over repeated uses, the system favours the patterns you tend to stay with and touch more when it is active.

Privacy and Audio Security

Smushie uses your voice only to understand the **current interaction**

The system processes audio **in real time** to estimate emotion, the raw sound is not kept permanently.

- No voice recordings are stored on the device or uploaded anywhere as part of normal use.
- Interaction logs, contain only simple technical information (for example, which emotion was detected, which pattern was chosen, whether Smushie was touched), and are used only for project evaluation.
- Smushie does not try to identify who you are, it treats all users anonymously.

Safety and Care

- Smushie is a delicate prototype: avoid dropping it, pressing hard on it, or spilling liquids on it.
 - Do not look directly into the LEDs from very close range for long periods.
 - The vibration motor is low power, but you should not press it firmly against sensitive skin.
 - If anything feels unusually hot, if you smell burning, or if Smushie behaves strangely, unplug it immediately.
-